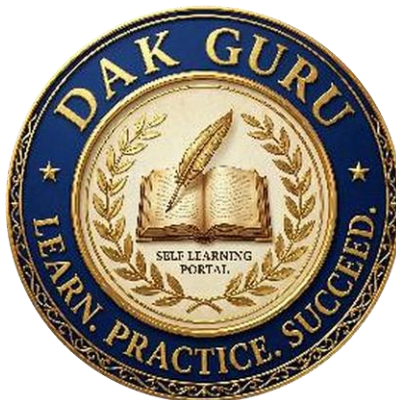




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## Book of Branch Office Rules

*Postal Manual Volume VI, Part III — Working of Branch Offices*

**For LDCE Inspector of Posts • PS Group 'B' Aspirants**

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*Verified against the Post Office Act 2023, Post Office Rules & Regulations 2024 and latest Directorate / SB Orders*

### DISCLAIMER

*This booklet has been prepared strictly from an examination point of view. While every effort has been made to ensure accuracy and to incorporate recent amendments, orders and notifications, this document is a study aid only. The internal working procedures of Branch Offices continue under the Postal Manual Volume VI; public-service rules now flow from the Post Office Act, 2023 and the Post Office Rules & Regulations, 2024. Monetary limits are revised by the Directorate from time to time. Readers are strongly advised to verify provisions against the official Gazette and current Directorate / SB Orders before relying on them in service.*

## How to Use This Booklet

This booklet condenses the **Working of Branch Offices** as laid down in **Postal Manual Volume VI, Part III**, the departmental manual that governs the day-to-day functioning of a **Gramin Dak Sevak (GDS) Branch Office (BO)** — its records, mail handling, sorting, registration, insurance, accounts and remittances. Rule numbers follow the Manual. Each rule below is given in three layers: the **text of the rule**, a plain-language **explanation of why it exists and how it works in practice**, and **colour-coded learning aids** for revision.

- **At a Glance** — the crisp one-line summary of a rule.
- **Exam Point** — a fact frequently tested or easily confused.
- **Definition** — a precise statutory meaning.
- **Memory Hook** — a device to lock the fact in.
- **Currency Flag** 🚩 — a figure or rule revised after the Manual, with the latest position and its source.
- **Trap Alert** ⚠️ — a common wrong answer to avoid.

### CURRENCY FLAG 🚩

**The big-picture change you must know first.** The colonial **Indian Post Office Act, 1898** (6 of 1898) has been **repealed** and replaced by the **Post Office Act, 2023** (43 of 2023), which received the President's assent on **24 December 2023** and came into force on **18 June 2024** (vide commencement notification **S.O. 2352(E) dated 17 June 2024**). The repeal is effected by **Section 16** of the 2023 Act, which also **saves** all existing rules, notifications and orders so far as they are not inconsistent with the new Act — which is why the BO working procedures in this booklet continue to operate.

The **Post Office Rules, 2024** and **Post Office Regulations, 2024** (Gazette, 16 December 2024) now provide the **public-facing service framework** (postage, prohibited articles, compensation, insurance ceilings). The **internal working procedures** of a BO (the forms, registers, sorting, remittances described here) continue under the Postal Manual and Directorate orders. Where a service limit in the old Manual has since been revised, a Currency Flag gives the live figure.

*Sources: Post Office Act 2023 (No. 43 of 2023), Section 1(2) & Section 16, [indiacode.nic.in](http://indiacode.nic.in); DoP commencement notification S.O. 2352(E) dated 17.06.2024; Post Office Rules & Regulations 2024, Gazette dated 16.12.2024.*

## Chapter 1 — Office Notices, Lists and Maps

### Rule 5 — Notice of Hours of Business

A **Notice of Hours of Business in Form M-6(c)** is supplied to each Branch Office by the **Sub-Divisional Inspector (SDI)**. It must be pasted on a notice board and hung prominently in the office so that it is clearly visible to the public.

**Why it matters.** A Branch Office in a village is often open for only a few hours a day, frequently at times that suit the BPM's other commitments. The public have a statutory right to know exactly when the counter will transact business, when the letter-box is cleared, and when mail is despatched. Displaying M-6(c) is therefore both a **transparency obligation** and the BPM's protection against complaints of arbitrary closure — if the notice is up and accurate, the BPM has discharged the duty.

#### EXAM POINT

**Form M-6(c)** = Notice of Hours of Business; supplied by the **SDI** (not the Head/Account Office); pasted and displayed publicly.

#### CURRENCY FLAG ■

Under the **Post Office Regulations, 2024**, a Branch Post Office may be kept open for a **maximum of five (5) hours a day**; the working hours of a departmental Post Office are **six (6) hours**. The Divisional / Regional Head is empowered to specify the exact business hours for each office and may authorise additional hours for high-demand services. So the hours shown on the M-6(c) must conform to the limit fixed under the 2024 Regulations.

*Source: Post Office Regulations, 2024 — business-hours provisions (BPO max 5 hrs/day; departmental PO 6 hrs).*

### Rule 7 — Village Sorting List, Route List and Beat Map

These three records together define **who delivers where, by what route, and on which day**. They are the operational backbone of rural delivery and are prepared by the Sub-Division.

#### Village Sorting List (Form M-52)

Lists, **in alphabetical order**, the villages served by each Assistant Branch Postmaster (ABPM). Against each village it shows whether a **letter box** exists, and whether that box carries a **changeable plate** — the small plate displaying the next clearance time, changed by the ABPM on each visit. Alphabetical order is not cosmetic: it lets the sorting ABPM place an article into the correct village bundle quickly and lets an inspecting officer verify coverage at a glance.

#### Route List (Form M-53) and Beat Map

The route list is accompanied by a **map of the beat** and specifies:

- The route the ABPM must follow on the beat.
- The days fixed for departure from, and return to, the Post Office.
- The specific day on which each village is to be visited.
- The villages where the ABPM is permitted to halt (relevant where a beat spans more than one day).

**Display.** The village sorting list and copies of the route lists and beat maps must be **hung up in the post office**. This makes the delivery schedule a public, checkable document — a villager can see which day to expect post, and a relieving ABPM can run the beat correctly in the regular ABPM's absence.

#### MEMORY HOOK

**“Sort by 52, Route by 53.”** M-52 = Village Sorting List (the smaller number, paired with Sorting); M-53 = Route List + beat map.

#### TRAP ALERT ⚠

The **changeable plate** is a feature of the **letter box**, recorded in the M-52 — it is not a separate form. Do not confuse “changeable plate” with any register.

### Rule 8 — Due Mail List and Sorting List

A due mail and sorting list tells a BO exactly which bags it should send and receive, and what each bag should contain. It is supplied to:

1. Every BO in direct communication with the Railway Mail Service (RMS) — by the Superintendent, RMS concerned.
2. Every other BO acting as a transit or sorting office — by the Superintendent of Post Offices.

**Why two different authorities.** A BO that exchanges mail directly with a mail train / RMS section is part of the **RMS network**, so its schedule is set by the Supdt. RMS. A BO that merely passes mail on to, or sorts for, neighbouring post offices sits within the **postal (SPOs) network**, so its schedule is set by the Supdt. of Post Offices. The supplying authority follows the network the BO actually plugs into.

#### DEFINITION

**Due Mail List** — shows the bag(s) to be received or despatched to each office or section, and specifies when bags must be accompanied by **mail lists** (the document listing accountable contents).

**Sorting List** — details the articles to be sent in each bag by the Branch Office.

#### EXAM POINT

“**Due**” = what is **due** to move (which bags, when). “**Sorting**” = how to **fill** each bag. One is the timetable, the other is the packing list.

#### TRAP ALERT ⚠

**RMS-linked BO** → Supdt. RMS; **transit/sorting BO** → Supdt. of Post Offices. Swapping the two authorities is the classic one-mark trap.

## Chapter 2 — Delivery and Staff Supervision

### Rule 9 — Supervision of Delivery Staff

The Branch Postmaster (BPM) supervises the village postman / delivery agents through a small set of records. The point of these records is **accountability for accountable articles** — every registered article, eMO or sum of money handed to a delivery agent must be traceable, and every village on the beat must be demonstrably covered.

| Record                     | Form  | Purpose / Usage                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Postman Book               | MS-27 | The Postman enters details of articles and e-Money Orders (eMO) received from the BPM for delivery.                                                                                                  |
| Village Postman Register   | MS-85 | Register in which the Village Postman enters article and eMO details received from the BPM.                                                                                                          |
| Village Postman Visit Book | MS-86 | Village Postman records the villages visited / to be visited.<br><b>Red ink (by BPM)</b> = village to be visited on that specific trip; <b>Black ink (by BPM)</b> = village to be visited regularly. |

**How the ink convention works.** The BPM plans the beat in the Visit Book. Villages written in **black** are the standing, regular stops. When a village not on the regular daily round must be served on a particular day — because, say, a registered article or a money order has arrived for it — the BPM writes that village in **red** against the relevant trip, making the special visit unmistakable and auditable.

#### EXAM POINT

**MS-86 ink rule:** **Red** = compulsory on **that** trip; **Black** = regular visits. A perennial favourite — commit the colours to memory.

**MEMORY HOOK**

“Red = right now, this trip. Black = back again regularly.”

**AT A GLANCE**

**Weight limit (Note to Rule 9).** The weight of postal articles (including parcels) carried by a village postman / extra-departmental delivery agent must **not exceed 10 kg**.

**CURRENCY FLAG ■**

**The 10 kg figure has two faces — know both.** (i) As a **staff-carriage limit**, 10 kg is the maximum a village postman / delivery agent is required to carry on the beat. (ii) As a **booking limit**, a **Branch Office can book a parcel up to 10 kg only** — heavier parcels are booked at a departmental (sub/head) office.

Distinguish these from the **customer-side maximum parcel weight**, which is governed by the **Post Office Regulations, 2024**: a **registered parcel** may generally go up to **20 kg**, and **Speed Post / Business Parcel** up to **35 kg** — but those are booked at departmental offices, not at a BO. Treat 10 kg as the BO/staff figure and 20–35 kg as the network maximum.

*Sources: Postal Manual Vol VI (staff carriage; BO parcel booking up to 10 kg); Post Office Regulations 2024 / Post Office Guide Part I (registered parcel up to 20 kg, Speed Post / Business Parcel up to 35 kg).*

## Chapter 3 — Security, Cash and Equipment

### Rule 11 — Custody of Cash

It is **not mandatory** to supply a safe to every extra-departmental Branch Office. A safe may be provided at the **discretion of the Superintendent of Post Offices**, on a report and recommendation **supported by the SDI**.

**The logic.** Many BOs handle only modest sums and are housed in the BPM's own premises, so a safe everywhere would be wasteful. The decision is therefore **evidence-based**: the SDI, who inspects the office, reports on the cash actually handled and the security of the premises, and the Superintendent decides. The provision balances **security against economy**.

**CURRENCY FLAG ■**

**BO cash-handling limits have moved well beyond the Manual — three figures the exam now expects:**

- **Deposit cap:** no BPM may accept a **cash deposit of more than ₹50,000 in one account in a day**. Cheque transactions and withdrawals are **not** capped by this rule. (This replaced the earlier lower ceiling and was issued to ease difficulties faced by pensioners and SSA/PPF/rural depositors after Finacle GL-integration.)



- **Surplus cash / line limit:** cash held in a BO over its prescribed **line limit of remittance** must be cleared to the Account Office. The line limit is fixed **locally per BO** by the Division — it is not a single national figure.
- **Conveyance of surplus cash:** reimbursed at **₹30 per occasion** (amount below ₹1 lakh) or **₹50 per occasion** (₹1 lakh and above) plus actual public-transport fare; there is **no fixed cash-conveyance allowance**.

*Sources: SB Order revising para 18 of SB Order 05/2016 (deposit cap ₹50,000/account/day); GDS pay & allowances order dated 25.06.2018 (cash-conveyance reimbursement ₹30 / ₹50 per occasion + fare).*

## Rule 19 — Stamps and Seals

Every Branch Office is supplied with a **seal** and the following stamps:

1. A combined **name-and-date stamp** of rectangular shape — carries the office name and the date, impressed on articles posted/handled.
2. A **postage-due stamp** — used to mark unpaid / underpaid articles before charging the recipient.
3. A **number-slip name-stamp** — unless the BO does **no independent registration work** (a BO that cannot itself register articles does not need it).

**Hour type.** A BO that despatches mail in one direction **more than once a day** is supplied with date-stamps containing **hour type** — the stamp then shows not just the date but the despatch hour, so the time of handling can be fixed when more than one despatch occurs in a day.

**Usage.** The date stamp must be impressed on **every communication** addressed by the BPM to the Superintendent or SDI, in addition to other required stamps — fixing the date a communication actually left the office.

### EXAM POINT

**Hour type** is given only where there is **more than one despatch a day** in a direction. A single-despatch BO gets an ordinary date stamp.

## Rule 20 — Book of Postmarks (Form MS-18)

A Book of Postmarks in **Form MS-18** is maintained in every Branch Office.

- **Daily procedure:** impressions of **all stamps holding date / movable type**, and of the **seal if it contains movable type**, are taken **daily before use**.
- **Verification:** the BPM ensures the impressions are **distinct and clear**, and **initials the book every day** after all impressions have been taken.

**Why a daily impression.** Date stamps wear, clog, or get set to the wrong date. By taking a dated impression **before** the day's work begins, the office creates a daily record proving the stamp was legible and correctly set — a control that catches a defective or mis-set stamp before it spoils real mail and that supports any later investigation into a disputed postmark.

### MEMORY HOOK

"Stamp the book before you stamp the post." MS-18 = the stamp's daily fitness certificate.

## Chapter 4 — Records and Their Preservation

### Rule 21 — Preservation of Books and Forms

Records are preserved for prescribed periods so that accounts can be re-checked and disputes settled, then destroyed so that obsolete accountable stationery cannot be misused. The periods:

| Period               | Records                                                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3 years              | BO Account (PA-6) and BO Journal (PA-5) — the core money records.                                                                                                                  |
| 2 years              | Book of Receipts (MS-87(a)), registered lists, parcel lists, and mail lists.                                                                                                       |
| Destroy by shredding | Postman's Book of Receipts (MS-87), Book of Postmarks (MS-18) and Registered Journal (RP-51) — shredded in the BPM's presence to prevent reuse of serially-numbered receipt forms. |

**Why shredding matters.** Forms like MS-87 and RP-51 carry **pre-printed serial numbers** that the office assigns to real articles. A discarded but intact receipt book could be used to fabricate a receipt for an article never posted. Destroying these **in the BPM's presence** closes that fraud route — the witnessing is the control.

### TRAP ALERT ⚠

**3 years = PA-6 / PA-5; 2 years = MS-87(a) and the lists.** The exam loves to swap the period and the form — anchor "money records (PA) = 3 years."

### Rule 22 — Book of Receipts (Form MS-87(a))

Form MS-87(a) is the BO's general receipt book. It is used to issue receipts to:

- Senders of insured or V.P. (value-payable) articles — letter or parcel mail.
- Remitters of Money Orders.
- P.L.I. (Postal Life Insurance) policy-holders for premium payments.



- Payers of telegraph charges realised in cash.

Each receipt bears a **printed serial number**, which is assigned to the article or money order. The serial number is what ties a citizen's receipt to the office's own record — making each transaction independently traceable and any gap in the series immediately visible.

#### EXAM POINT

**MS-87(a)** covers four payers: **insured/VP senders, MO remitters, PLI premium payers, telegraph-charge payers**. It is the catch-all cash-receipt book at a BO.

### Rule 36 — Error Book (Form MS-2)

The Error Book (MS-2) is a **permanent record of all irregularities**, whether serious or petty. Its scope covers irregularities **committed by office staff** and those **noticed from other offices / sections** (for example, mis-sending or misdirection of articles received from elsewhere).

**Purpose.** The Error Book turns one-off mistakes into a **standing learning and accountability record**. Recurring errors become visible to inspecting officers; a pattern of mis-sends from a particular office can be taken up; and the BPM's own lapses are documented for review. Because it is a permanent record, it is **never routinely destroyed**.

#### EXAM POINT

**MS-2 = Error Book = permanent.** "Errors are forever." Records both own-office and other-office irregularities (e.g. misdirection).

### Rule 37-A — Suggestion / Complaint Book (Form MS-94)

- Every Branch Post Office **must maintain** a Complaint / Suggestion Book (MS-94).
- **Access:** kept in a **conspicuous place, easily accessible to the public without their having to ask for it** — the public must never have to request the book from the very official they may wish to complain about.
- **Format:** the public record complaints or suggestions **in duplicate** using a **carbonic process**, so the complainant retains a copy as proof of what was recorded.

#### DEFINITION

The duplicate / carbonic design is the safeguard: it makes it impossible to later alter or remove a complaint without the discrepancy showing against the citizen's retained copy.

### Rule 42 — Post Office Order Book (Form MS-8)

- **Purpose:** used by **inspecting officers** to record remarks and orders during inspection of the BO.

- **Responsibility:** the BPM is **personally responsible** for promptly taking action on these remarks.
- **Integrity:** each book contains **200 serially numbered pages**; **wilful removal of a page is a serious offence liable to removal from service.**
- **Status:** a **permanent record** — not destroyed without the **Superintendent's special permission.**

**Why so strictly protected.** The Order Book is the audit trail of supervision: it shows what defects were found and whether the BPM acted. Numbered pages and the removal-from-service sanction exist precisely because a dishonest official's incentive is to make an adverse remark disappear. The **200 numbered pages** make any missing page obvious.

#### MEMORY HOOK

Two BO books carry exactly **200 serially numbered units**: the **Order Book (MS-8)** = 200 pages, and the **Registered Journal (RP-51)** = 200 receipts. MS-8 is permanent; RP-51 is shredded.

### Rule 44 — Branch Office Circulars

Circulars issued by Heads of Circles in **regional languages** are supplied to all Branch Offices so that instructions reach BPMs in a language they read. They are destroyed **3 years** from the month of **April following the close of the official year** in which they were issued.

#### EXAM POINT

The 3-year clock for circulars starts from **April after the official year ends** — not from the date of issue. Count from the following April.

## Chapter 5 — Returns and Reports

### Rule 45 — Half-Yearly Enumeration Return (Form MS-6)

- **Timing:** the **second week of February and August** each year — the **8th to the 21st**, inclusive.
- **Submission:** a copy is forwarded to the Account Office by the **mail of the 15th.**
- **Data collected:** counts of ordinary unregistered letters, unregistered parcels delivered by postmen / village postmen / agents, and window delivery. **Service (official) articles are counted separately** from the public traffic.

**Why enumerate.** Unregistered traffic leaves no individual record, so the Department cannot otherwise know how much ordinary mail a BO handles. A twice-yearly **sample count** gives

the data used to assess the office's workload, justify staffing and establishment, and plan delivery — which is why service articles are kept separate, so the public-traffic figure is not inflated by the office's own mail.

### Rule 46 — Yearly Village Return (Form MS-88)

- **Timing:** maintained during the **first 14 days of March** each year — the **1st to the 14th**, inclusive.
- **Scope:** records **all articles (including money orders)** received daily for delivery in **each village**.
- **Submission:** totalled, signed by the BPM, and forwarded to the **ASPOs / SDI on the 15th**.

**Use of the data.** Where MS-6 measures the office's overall unregistered load, MS-88 measures **village-wise demand** — the basis for deciding whether a village's delivery frequency, a beat's design, or a new letter box is warranted.

#### EXAM POINT

**Three windows to lock in:** MS-6 enumeration = **Feb & Aug, 8–21**; MS-88 village return = **March, 1–14**; both reported on the 15th.

#### MEMORY HOOK

**"8 to 21 twice** (Feb/Aug), then **1 to 14 once** (March) — always post on the 15th."

### Rule 50 — Leave Applications

Applications for leave by an extra-departmental BPM are prepared in **Form App-45 in 4 copies** and submitted to the ASPOs / SDI. They are preserved for **3 years after the BPM's service ends**. The four copies allow the application to move through the approving and record-keeping channels while a copy remains traceable at each level.

#### CURRENCY FLAG ■

Conditions of engagement and leave of Gramin Dak Sevaks are now governed by the **GDS (Conduct and Engagement) Rules, 2020**, which **superseded the GDS (Conduct and Engagement) Rules, 2011**. Leave, the Service Discharge Benefit Scheme and related entitlements are administered under those Rules and through the **online GDS Engagement Portal (APT 2.0)**. The Form App-45 procedure here is the manual record; verify the current leave quantum and procedure from the 2020 Rules.

*Source: GDS (Conduct & Engagement) Rules, 2020, Department of Posts (superseding the 2011 Rules).*

## Chapter 6 — Mail Handling and Sorting

### Rule 53 — Bags Received with Signs of Tampering

If a bag is found with **missing cash / articles or signs of tampering**, the BPM must:

1. **Report immediately** to the Superintendent **and** the despatching office / section.
2. **Preserve the bag and label without detaching the seal / cord**; mark them with the BPM's initials and the date stamp.
3. Record the irregularity in the **Error Book (MS-2)**.

**Why preserve the seal intact.** The **seal and cord are the physical evidence** of how and where the bag was interfered with. Detaching or opening them would destroy the proof and could shift suspicion onto the receiving office. The correct sequence is **preserve → mark → report → record** — never open or dismantle.

#### TRAP ALERT ⚠

**Never detach the seal or cord.** The instinct to “open and check” is wrong — preserve it as evidence, mark it, and report. Reporting goes to **both** the Superintendent and the despatching office.

### Rule 59 — Clearance of Letter-Boxes

- Clearance is at hours **fixed by the ASPOs / SDI** — not chosen ad hoc by the BPM.
- **Paid articles** intended for delivery from the BO itself are **delivered immediately**.
- **Sorting:** all other articles are sorted per the sorting list, or set aside for despatch to the Account Office.
- **Stamping:** unregistered articles received in sorting **for despatch** must **not** be stamped by the Branch Office — the office of posting / first sorting office stamps them, to avoid double or wrong-office postmarks.
- **Invalid stamps:** non-Indian postage stamps **cannot be accepted** and **must not be defaced** — defacing a foreign stamp would wrongly suggest it had been recognised as valid Indian postage.

#### EXAM POINT

Two “don’ts” here: don’t stamp unregistered articles received **for despatch**; and don’t deface **non-Indian** stamps.

## Rule 62 – Unpaid and Insecure Articles

- **Action:** open or insecure inland articles found in the letter-box or in sorting must be **securely closed** before onward handling, to protect the contents.
- **Taxing:** stamp “Postage Due” if unpaid / insufficiently paid; **note the amount due** before forwarding, so the delivery office can collect it.
- **Accounting:** do **not** credit the unpaid-postage amount in the BO Account or Journal (PA-5) at this stage — it is collected at delivery, not booked as BO revenue here.

### TRAP ALERT ⚠

“Postage Due” at this stage is a **marking, not a BO credit**. The money is realised on delivery; it is not entered as cash collected at the despatching/sorting BO.

## Rule 64 – Check Slips (Form MS-10)

A check slip is a **label tied to the top of a labelled bundle**, colour-coded so a sorting assistant can identify the bundle type instantly without opening it:

| Colour                 | Bundle type                                                                                                   |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pink                   | Ordinary Station Paid and Unpaid bundle.                                                                      |
| White                  | Ordinary Sorting bundle (used for both Express and Deferred). Two diagonal blue lines mark an Express bundle. |
| Blue (with “Air Mail”) | Foreign air-mail bundles.                                                                                     |

### MEMORY HOOK

“**Pink Pays, White Works, Blue Flies.**” Pink = Paid (station); White = sorting (**W**ork); Blue = air mail (“flies”). The **two diagonal blue lines on a white slip** = Express.

## Rule 65 – Labelled Bundles

A **labelled bundle** groups unregistered articles for efficient sorting. The type depends on destination spread and is prepared once a threshold number of articles is reached:

| Bundle             | Definition & threshold                                                                              |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Station bundle     | Unregistered articles for one particular station. Prepared at 15 or more articles for that station. |
| Sorting bundle     | Unregistered articles for many stations (mixed-destination).                                        |
| Territorial bundle | A sorting bundle for a specific State / tract of country. Prepared at 25 or more articles.          |

| Bundle          | Definition & threshold                                 |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Express bundle  | Requires immediate sorting on receipt (time-critical). |
| Deferred bundle | May be disposed of later (not time-critical).          |

**How the thresholds work.** Making up a dedicated bundle saves the receiving office sorting effort, but only pays off above a minimum volume — hence **15** articles to justify a single-station bundle and **25** to justify a territorial bundle. Below the threshold, the articles simply travel in the general sorting bundle.

#### EXAM POINT

**Thresholds: Station = 15, Territorial = 25.** “1-5 for one Station; 2-5 for a Territory.” Express vs Deferred is about **urgency**, not numbers.

### Rule 66 — Delivery of Unregistered Articles

- **Stamping:** articles received for delivery are date-stamped on the **back**; the exception is **postcards**, stamped on the **address side**.
- **Redirection:** if handed to a village postman / agent for delivery **outside the town / village**, they are **stamped again**, recording the further movement.
- **Postage due:** amounts due on unpaid articles are entered in the **BO Journal (PA-5)** — here, where the charge is realised on local delivery.
- **Foreign post:** an article received by foreign post must **never** be taxed with postage by the Branch Office.

**Note the contrast with Rule 62.** Under Rule 62 (articles for **despatch**), the unpaid amount is **not** booked in the PA-5. Under Rule 66 (articles for **local delivery**), the postage due **is** entered in the PA-5 — because this office is the one that actually collects it.

#### TRAP ALERT ⚠

Two exceptions to memorise: **postcards stamped on the address side** (not the back), and **foreign-post articles never taxed** at the BO.

### Rule 67 — Postage Taxing at the Branch Office

- The BPM must properly tax all unpaid / insufficiently paid unregistered articles **posted at the BO and intended for local delivery**.
- **Registered newspapers:** the **office of posting** is responsible for correct postage. The office of delivery should **not** challenge it unless negligence is suspected, in which case a report goes to the Superintendent.



**DEFINITION**

“Taxing” = assessing and marking the postage / fee payable on an unpaid or short-paid article so that it can be collected from the recipient on delivery.

## Chapter 7 — Registration and Insurance

### Rule 77 — Registered Journal (Form RP-51)

- **Usage:** records receipts given to senders of **ordinary registered articles** — **excluding V.P. and insured** articles, which are receipted in the MS-87(a).
- **Numbering:** contains **200 receipts** with printed serial numbers running **1 to 200**.

**EXAM POINT**

**RP-51 = ordinary registered only.** V.P. and insured go in the **MS-87(a)**, not the RP-51. Both books run to 200 serial numbers.

### Rule 79 — Registered and Parcel Lists

- **Registered List = Form RP-32.** Lists the registered articles despatched.
- **Parcel List = Form RP-3.** Lists the parcels despatched.
- **Corrections:** corrections to entry numbers or office of posting must be **initialled by the BPM**.
- **Prohibition:** no correction is allowed in the **total** of entries; if the total is wrong, the **list is destroyed and a fresh one prepared**.

**Why the total may never be corrected.** The total is the control figure the receiving office checks the contents against. Allowing it to be over-written would let an article be quietly added or removed after preparation. Forcing a **fresh list** keeps the control figure tamper-evident.

**MEMORY HOOK**

“RP-3 = Parcels (P), RP-32 = Registered.” Entries may be corrected with initials; the **total** may never — rewrite the whole list.

### Rule 80 — Acknowledgement (Foreign)

A registered article addressed to a foreign country requiring an acknowledgement is clearly marked “**Avis de réception**” (French for “advice of receipt”, the term used in the Universal Postal Union framework). The marking tells every office in the chain, including the foreign delivery office, that proof of delivery must be obtained and returned.

**EXAM POINT**

**“Avis de réception”** = the acknowledgement marking on a **foreign** registered article. Know the spelling — it appears verbatim in questions.

**Rule 85 — Registered Articles Found in the Letter-Box**

- **Procedure:** if an inland article marked “Registered” is found in the letter-box, it must be **registered immediately** — the sender’s evident intention to register is honoured.
- **Penalty:** if **not fully prepaid**, charge a fee equal to **double the usual registration fee plus the postage due**.

**The rationale.** Registration must be done at the counter so the sender gets a receipt and the article enters the accountable stream. Dropping a “Registered” article into the box bypasses that. The office still registers it (to protect the article), but the **double fee** both deters the practice and compensates for the irregular handling.

**MEMORY HOOK**

Found-in-box registered, short-paid = **double registration fee + postage due**. “Skip the counter, pay it double.”

**Rule 93 — Conditions of Insurance**

Registered letters and parcels (including V.P.) may be insured at a Branch Office against loss or damage in transit. The Manual’s traditional figure for **independent BO booking** is **₹600**, but the insurance ceiling is one of the most-revised limits in the postal system — see the Currency Flag.

**CURRENCY FLAG ■**

**Insurance limits have risen sharply — keep two layers straight:**

- **System-wide maximum:** the maximum insurable value for **domestic accountable articles** is now **₹5,00,000 (₹5 lakh)**, raised from ₹1 lakh by the **Post Office (Third Amendment) Regulations, 2026**, which amended **Regulation 133** of the Post Office Regulations 2024 (Gazette dated **25 March 2026**; effective **1 April 2026**).
- **Branch-Office booking authority:** a BO’s own booking limit depends on its classification and whether it runs on **RICT / DARPAN** devices; technology-enabled BOs book insured articles well above the legacy ₹600 ceiling. Treat ₹600 as the **old manual figure**, not the current operational cap — confirm a specific BO’s authority from Divisional orders.

*Sources: Post Office (Third Amendment) Regulations, 2026, Gazette dated 25.03.2026, amending Regulation 133 of the Post Office Regulations 2024 (₹1 lakh → ₹5 lakh, w.e.f. 01.04.2026).*

## Rule 94 — Treatment of Insured Articles

- **Reference check:** consult the **Post Office Guide Volume III** to confirm the destination office accepts insured articles — ensure no symbol **“B”** or **“L”** against it indicating a restriction. Booking an insured article to an office that cannot handle it would strand the article.
- **Fees:** acknowledgements for **inland insured letters (RP-54)** are **free**; **foreign insured letters** require a special fee if an acknowledgement is requested.

### EXAM POINT

Restriction symbols **“B”** / **“L”** in the Post Office Guide Vol III flag offices that **do not** accept insured articles. Inland RP-54 acknowledgement = **free**; foreign = **paid**.

## Chapter 8 — Accounts and Remittances

### Rule 124 — Branch Office Account (Form PA-6)

The PA-6 is the BO's master money record. It **records monetary transactions between the BO and the Account Office**. Four placement rules govern how specific items appear in it:

- **Exclusion:** cash realised from **postage collections** must **never** be included in “Cash collected” (postage is revenue accounted differently, not BO cash held for the AO).
- **V.P. articles:** amounts collected for V.P. articles delivered are credited under **“Money orders issued”** — because the V.P. value is remitted to the sender exactly like a money order.
- **Reply coupons:** the value of stamps exchanged for reply-coupons is shown under **“Unclassified payments”**.

**Why these placements are tested.** Each item could plausibly be mis-booked under “cash collected”, and each has a specific, counter-intuitive home. Getting them right is what keeps the BO and AO figures reconcilable.

### TRAP ALERT ⚠

Three placement traps: postage collections are **excluded** from “Cash collected”; V.P. recoveries go under **Money Orders Issued**; reply-coupon stamp value goes under **Unclassified Payments**.

## Rule 129 – Monthly Abstract in the BO Bag

The Branch Office bag closed on the **1st of each month** must contain the **Abstract of Monetary Transactions** for the **entire preceding month**, submitted in **Form PA-7**. This monthly abstract is what lets the Account Office reconcile the BO's month as a whole against the daily figures it has received.

### EXAM POINT

**PA-7 = Monthly Abstract**, sent in the BO bag closed on the **1st**, covering the **whole previous month**.

## Rule 130 – Remittances Sent Through Post

The Manual prescribes two traditional bag types for sending cash by post between offices:

- **Cloth bags** — for remittances of **currency notes only, up to ₹500**.
- **Leather cash bags** — for remittances **including coins**, or **exceeding ₹500** (coins are heavier and abrasive, so a sturdier bag is required).

### CURRENCY FLAG ■

These ₹500-era bag rules are **legacy figures**. Cash-conveyance protocols have been substantially revised: **line limits are fixed by Circle / Divisional orders** (and per BO); large sums move under specified **security arrangements** (special carrier, escort) rather than by a fixed bag-type cut-off; and the cloth-vs-leather distinction now turns largely on the **mode of conveyance** and local orders. Treat ₹500 as the Manual baseline, not the current line limit — confirm the BO's actual line limit from the Divisional Office.

*Source: Directorate / Circle cash-conveyance orders; remittance line limit fixed locally per BO (not a single national figure).*

## Rule 134 – Preparation of the BO Daily Account

- **Process:** entries from the BO Account (PA-6) are copied into the **BO Daily Account (Form ACG-22(a))** for daily submission to the Account Office.
- **Nil days:** on a day with **no monetary transaction**, the account is submitted in **Form ACG-22(c)** instead of ACG-22(a) — a positive “nil” return, so the AO knows the day was accounted for and not merely missed.

### EXAM POINT

**ACG-22(a)** = normal BO Daily Account; **ACG-22(c)** = Nil-transaction day. “(a) for activity, (c) for ciphers.”

**CURRENCY FLAG ■**

In **CSI / RICT BOs**, the BO Daily Account (BODA) is largely **system-generated** through the RICT device and reconciled by the Account Office in **Finacle**; the manual ACG-22(a) / 22(c) forms persist for **non-CSI (manual) BOs** and for reconciliation purposes. Know both the form names and the digital workflow.

*Source: DoP Cash Management SOP — CSI / RICT BO Daily Account (BODA) reconciliation in Finacle.*

**Account-Office Documentation (Forms Prepared by the A.O.)**

Two forms are prepared at the **Account Office** side for reconciliation of BO accounts — the BO and AO documents are designed to be checked against each other:

- **BO Slip (Form PA-4)** — the primary communication / accounting slip sent **from the Account Office to the Branch Office**.
- **BO Summary (Form ACG-3(a))** — a summary prepared **at the Account Office** consolidating the daily transactions of the Branch Office.

**EXAM POINT**

**Direction matters: PA-4 (BO Slip)** goes **AO → BO**; the BO's own daily account (ACG-22(a)) goes **BO → AO**.

**Appendix A — Master Schedule of Prescribed Forms**

A consolidated reference to every statutory form and register named in this booklet.

| Form   | Title                          | Purpose                                              |
|--------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| M-6(c) | Notice of Hours of Business    | Displayed publicly in the office.                    |
| M-52   | Village Sorting List           | Villages served by ABPM; letter-box locations.       |
| M-53   | Route List                     | Route, schedule and halts for the ABPM.              |
| MS-2   | Error Book                     | Permanent record of all irregularities.              |
| MS-6   | Half-yearly Enumeration Return | Unregistered-article statistics (Feb & Aug).         |
| MS-8   | Order Book                     | Remarks / orders of inspecting officers (200 pages). |
| MS-10  | Check Slip                     | Label on labelled bundles (Pink / White / Blue).     |
| MS-18  | Book of Postmarks              | Daily record of stamp & seal impressions.            |
| MS-27  | Postman Book                   | Articles / cash given to the Postman.                |

| Form      | Title                       | Purpose                                                          |
|-----------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MS-85     | Village Postman Register    | Village Postman transaction register.                            |
| MS-86     | Village Postman Visit Book  | Village visits (Red / Black ink entries).                        |
| MS-87(a)  | Book of Receipts            | Receipts for insured / VP articles, MOs, PLI, telegraph charges. |
| MS-88     | Yearly Village Return       | Article statistics per village (March).                          |
| MS-94     | Complaint / Suggestion Book | Public record for grievances & suggestions (duplicate).          |
| PA-4      | B.O. Slip                   | Accounting slip from A.O. to B.O.                                |
| PA-5      | B.O. Journal                | Daily record of B.O. transactions.                               |
| PA-6      | B.O. Account                | Monetary-transaction record between B.O. and A.O.                |
| PA-7      | Monthly Abstract            | Abstract of monetary transactions (sent on the 1st).             |
| ACG-3(a)  | B.O. Summary                | Prepared at A.O. to summarise B.O. accounts.                     |
| ACG-22(a) | B.O. Daily Account          | Daily submission of accounts to A.O.                             |
| ACG-22(c) | B.O. Daily Account (Nil)    | Submitted on Nil-transaction days.                               |
| RP-3      | Parcel List                 | List of parcels despatched.                                      |
| RP-32     | Registered List             | List of registered articles despatched.                          |
| RP-51     | Registered Journal          | Receipts for ordinary registered articles (200).                 |
| RP-54     | Acknowledgement             | For inland registered / insured articles.                        |
| App-45    | Leave Application           | Leave application form for GDS / ABPM (4 copies).                |

## Appendix B – Currency and Compliance Note

### AT A GLANCE

**Why this appendix exists.** Several figures in the Book of BO Rules are baseline values from the Postal Manual. The Directorate revises them through orders, SB Orders and Gazette amendments. Always confirm the live figure with the Divisional Office before relying on it in service. The position below is current as on 24 June 2026.



## 1. Framework — Post Office Act 2023 & Regulations 2024

The **Indian Post Office Act, 1898** (6 of 1898) has been **repealed** by the **Post Office Act, 2023** (43 of 2023), which received Presidential assent on **24 December 2023** and came into force on **18 June 2024** (commencement notification S.O. 2352(E) dated 17 June 2024). The repeal-and-savings provision is **Section 16** of the 2023 Act. The **Post Office Rules, 2024** and **Post Office Regulations, 2024** (Gazette, 16 December 2024) provide the public-service framework; the internal BO procedures in this booklet continue under the Postal Manual. Read the two together.

## 2. Insurance Limit (Rule 93)

Manual figure for independent BO booking: **₹600**. Current system-wide maximum for domestic accountable articles: **₹5,00,000**, raised from ₹1 lakh by the **Post Office (Third Amendment) Regulations, 2026** amending **Regulation 133** of the Post Office Regulations 2024 (Gazette dated 25 March 2026; effective 1 April 2026). Technology-enabled (RICT / DARPAN) BOs book well above ₹600.

## 3. Cash Acceptance & Conveyance (Rules 11, 130)

- **Deposit cap:** no BPM may accept a cash deposit of more than **₹50,000 per account per day** (revised; cheques and withdrawals not capped by this rule).
- **Remittance bags / line limit:** the ₹500 cloth-bag / leather-bag cut-off is a legacy figure. The **line limit of remittance** is fixed by Circle / Divisional orders, per BO; large sums move under specified security arrangements.
- **Conveyance of surplus cash:** reimbursed at **₹30 per occasion** (below ₹1 lakh) or **₹50 per occasion** (₹1 lakh and above) plus actual fare; no fixed cash-conveyance allowance.

## 4. Article Weight (Rule 9)

The **10 kg** limit applies both as the manual-carriage limit for a village postman / delivery agent **and** as the maximum parcel a **Branch Office may book**. The customer-side network maxima — **registered parcel up to ~20 kg, Speed Post / Business Parcel up to 35 kg** — are governed by the Post Office Regulations 2024 / Post Office Guide Part I and are booked at departmental offices, not at a BO.

## 5. Business Hours (Rule 5)

Under the **Post Office Regulations, 2024**, a Branch Post Office is kept open for a **maximum of five hours a day** (a departmental Post Office observes six business hours); the Divisional / Regional Head fixes the exact hours.

## 6. GDS Service Rules (Rule 50)

Conditions of engagement and leave of Gramin Dak Sevaks are governed by the **GDS (Conduct and Engagement) Rules, 2020** (which superseded the 2011 Rules), administered through the online GDS Engagement Portal (APT 2.0).

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— End of Booklet —

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